

READY, SET, SERVE

Planning a festive feast? Let your serveware do the heavy lifting. Here's how to master the art of plating so that it steals the spotlight

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Photographs by HARDIK CHHABRA

What makes a Diwali gathering special? Often, it's the little things we remember long after the evening and festivities are over. The food, the flowers, the warm glow of diyas and candles and the choice of tableware all join hands to set the mood. This season, the art of plating is about bringing these details together with a little more thought, creativity and personality to the table. For Neha Gupta, entrepreneur, restaurateur and founder of Forest Table, the idea is to embrace the richness of Diwali without going overboard on the gold and glitter. "I would rather bring in deep festive colours such as burnt orange, maroon, saffron, greens, yellow and a little gold and balance them with natural textures," she says. The idea is to keep the food generous and inviting rather than excessively constructed. So, the plate would have layers of colour and texture with enough space for each element to be appreciated. Tradition should remain recognisable and you can reinterpret how something is presented without taking away what makes it Indian.

Shared Plates, Deeper Bonds

Contemporary plating is about editing, not changing the soul of the food. A familiar dish can be presented in a cleaner, more refined way, while the table setting, serveware, table linen and other details around it continue to carry that sense of warmth. Abundance should be felt rather than displayed. A table that is generously laid with dishes meant to be passed around and shared immediately creates a feeling of togetherness. Food is very much about the experience around it. "I like the idea of dishes arriving at the centre of the table, people helping themselves and conversations continuing over food," says Gupta. That is what Indian hospitality is about.